About Typhoid Fever and Paratyphoid Fever

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For Everyone

KEY POINTS

- Typhoid fever and paratyphoid fever are life-threatening illnesses.
- Each of the illnesses is caused by a kind of *Salmonella* bacteria (germs).
- Most people in the United States with these illnesses were infected during international travel.
- You can find out if you need a typhoid fever vaccine at www.cdc.gov/travel.

Overview

Symptoms

Typhoid fever and paratyphoid fever have similar symptoms, including fever. The illnesses are life-threatening and people with symptoms should get medical help immediately.

Germs responsible

The illnesses are caused by *Salmonella* bacteria.

- Typhoid fever is caused by *Salmonella* serotype Typhi.
- Paratyphoid fever is caused by *Salmonella* serotype Paratyphi.

Illness estimates

Every year, millions of people around the world get sick from these diseases.

Typhoid fever

- 9.2 million illnesses are estimated to occur worldwide each year
- 5,700 illnesses and 620 hospitalizations are estimated to occur in the United States each year. Most people are infected while traveling internationally.

Paratyphoid fever

- 3.8 million illnesses are estimated to occur worldwide each year
- CDC does not have estimates of illnesses and hospitalizations in the United States

Where illness is common

These illnesses are most common in parts of the world where water and food can be unsafe, and sanitation can be poor, including parts of:

- Asia (especially Pakistan, India, and Bangladesh)
- Africa

- Latin America

Most people in the United States with typhoid fever or paratyphoid fever were infected while traveling to these places.

Risk factors

The chances of getting typhoid fever or paratyphoid fever in the United States are very low.

The chances increase for people in the United States who:

- Travel to countries in Africa, Asia, or Latin America where the diseases are common
- Visit rural areas of those countries
- Visit family and friends in those countries
- Are not vaccinated against typhoid fever

Almost all people in the United States with these diseases report that they have traveled internationally. Most report that they traveled to countries in South Asia, including Pakistan, India, or Bangladesh.

How it spreads

The bacteria spread to and among people in several ways

The bacteria that cause these illnesses are shed (gotten rid of) in poop. People who shed the bacteria include:

- People who have symptoms of typhoid fever or paratyphoid fever
- People who are no longer sick but still have the bacteria in their body

You can get typhoid fever or paratyphoid fever after swallowing the bacteria. The bacteria can get in your mouth in several ways, including:

- Through food, drinks, and water that have been contaminated by sewage
- Through food that has been rinsed in contaminated water and then eaten
- Through food that has been touched by a person who did not wash their hands after using the bathroom or changing a diaper

You can take steps to keep safe from these diseases

KEEP READING:
Preventing Typhoid Fever and Paratyphoid Fever

SOURCES

CONTENT SOURCE:
National Center for Emerging and Zoonotic Infectious Diseases (NCEZID)